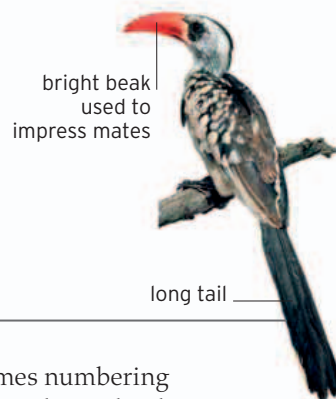


Red-billed hornbill

Tockus erythrorhynchus



Groups of red-billed hornbills, sometimes numbering hundreds, wander through thorn bush and grasslands looking for food, which is mostly taken on the ground.

They build their nests in tree-holes or hollow logs. The female seals herself inside with mud up to 24 days before laying eggs, which take about the same time to hatch. All this time, the male brings her food. She breaks out 21 days later, when the oldest chick is ready to fly.



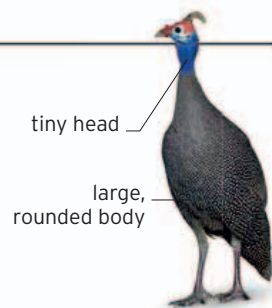
- ↔ 16–19 in (41–48 cm)
- ⚖ 4–8 oz (113–227 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Dung beetles, seeds
- 🏠 🌳 🌳 Sub-Saharan Africa

◁ FLAP-AND-GLIDE FLIGHT

Hornbills hunt prey on the ground during the day, but they fly back to trees to roost at night.

Helmeted guineafowl

Numida meleagris



Abundant in bushy savannas, helmeted guineafowl are named for the bony casque on their head. They need drinking water, thick cover to escape into if threatened, and trees to roost in at night. They eat seeds and shoots, but prefer grasshoppers and termites when abundant.

- ↔ 21–25 in (53–64 cm)
- ⚖ 2–3 lb (0.9–1.4 kg)
- ⊗ Common
- 🐛 Seeds, shoots, insects
- 🏠 🌳 🌳 Sub-Saharan Africa



▷ BOLTING AWAY

Guineafowl live in busy, noisy groups on the ground. They run rather than fly from danger, unless sorely pressed.

Secretary bird

Sagittarius serpentarius

The secretary bird strides along elegantly on extraordinarily long legs in grassy plains, its head bobbing back and forth. It feeds mainly on grasshoppers, mice, and voles, but will eat anything it can kill. Long, bare legs help protect it from snakes, even deadly cobras, which it kills by stomping.

Each breeding pair needs about 20 sq miles (50 sq km) of “home range” for nesting. They drive out rival birds from their territories, jumping and kicking if they catch an intruder.

- ↔ 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
- ⚖ 9 lb (4 kg)
- ⊗ Vulnerable
- 🐛 Grasshoppers, mice, voles
- 🏠 🌳 🌳



Sub-Saharan Africa



△ SNAKE SNACK

Secretary birds stalk determinedly across open grassland in search of prey, which even includes venomous snakes.